

## **Lesson 2 – Upanishads: Philosophy and Knowledge**

### **Learning objectives:**

- 1] Understand the origins, authorship, and historical context of the Upanishads.
- 2] Explore the philosophical underpinnings and the metaphysical concepts of the Upanishads.
- 3] Examine the teachings of Major Upanishads and Their relevance.
- 4] Grasp the concepts of Brahman, Atman and Maya in the Upanishads.
- 5] Recognise the influence of Upanishads on Indian thought, culture and contemporary societies.

### **Topic 1 - Origins of Upanishads**

Friends, let us know something about the Upanishads. I'm sure you must have heard this word or read this word many times. So what are the Upanishads? Upanishads come at the end of the Vedic literature. So you must have seen the layers of the Vedic literature. And Upanishads are the end of the Vedic texts. So they are also called Vedanta. Let's try to understand the concept of Upanishad as well as the word Vedanta. The word Upanishad is a Sanskrit word. It has three components. So to say upa plus ni plus sadh. Sadh is the actual verb. It means to sit, and UPA and knee. Add some more meaning to this Verb. UPA means close and knee means down. So you can imagine a guru and his disciples, or Shishyas, sitting at his feet to get the mystic knowledge. The knowledge which you see in the Upanishads is not any ordinary knowledge, but it is a very philosophical, mystic kind of knowledge. And therefore, the students used to sit at the feet of the guru. And therefore it is called UpanisHad. It is also called Vedanta because, as I said, it comes at the end of the Vedic text. But there is one more reason behind it. The word AnTha also means the core. So it is also interpreted that because the Upanishads reflect the core knowledge of the Vedic ideas, it is called Vedanta. And there is one more reason. When the students used to study the Vedic literature, the Vedic studies, they used to study the Upanishads at the end. Even now, the same pattern is followed. And that is why also it is called Vedanta.

**Origins of The Upanishads** If you have ever peeled an onion, think of the Upanishads as the core housing the deepest wisdom of Indian philosophy. The word Upanishad originates from the Sanskrit root words "upa" which means

near and "ni" which means down, and "shad" which means to sit, symbolising the student and teacher setting where knowledge is imparted as sitting down near the teacher to learn wisdom. Imagine a timeline starting from the very dawn of human civilisation. The Upanishads were composed during the latter part of the Vedic period, roughly between 800 to 500 BCE, when the bustling Indus Valley civilisation was waning and new philosophies were emerging, much like the creative bursts in the modern startup scene. Think of the Upanishads as a vast library containing 108 texts. But not all books in a library are equally famous, right? Similarly, ten to 13 Upanishads are considered principal or major older Upanishads, with the rest being categorized as minor, much like the many apps on our smartphones, with a few being most frequently used. Ever watched a long movie series or read a multiview saga? The Upanishads are like the grand finale, constituting the concluding parts of the Vedas, which are the oldest sacred texts of Hinduism. This is why they are referred to as Vedant, meaning the end of the veds, akin to the climax or resolution of a gripping tale. Do you know how we share popular stories or songs verbally from one person to another? Similarly, the Upanishads were traditionally attributed to ancient sages called rishis, and were transmitted orally through generations like a secret whisper passed from teacher to student, preserving its essence over millennia. In a way, the Upanishads were like a cultural revolution, shifting focus from ritualistic practices, like attending a formal event, towards philosophical inquiries. Similar to late night conversations about life mysteries, they aim to answer questions about the nature of reality, human existence and the ultimate truth, sparking curiosity, much like the intriguing questions posed by modern science.

## **Topic 2 - Philosophical underpinnings of the Upanishads**

As I said, Upanishads have philosophical content, and the Upanishads are world famous in the field of philosophy. They are the foundation of the deep Indian philosophy. Now, what is the speciality of the Indian philosophy? The Indian philosophy, the traditional Indian philosophy says that actually everything is one, and the variety or the multiplicity is just felt, it is just seen. And all this takes us to the ideas of Atman and Brahman. Just as the many rivers of India all eventually lead to the ocean, so too does the Indian philosophy, with its diverse strands, eventually converge on a few fundamental truths. This varied body of knowledge is akin to the Indian spice bazaar, brimming with a myriad of colors, textures, and flavours. A key component of this philosophical bazaar is the Upanishads, which provide insights into the profound mysteries of existence,

much like how a street lamp illuminates a dark path. Consider the Upanishads as a canvas upon which the grandest cosmic truths are painted. They delve into metaphysical concepts such as Brahman, which is the ultimate reality, Atman, the individual soul, and Maya, which means the illusory nature of the world. Not unlike the various elements that come together to form a beautiful Indian rangoli pattern, these concepts, though complex, are conveyed through simple, relatable analogies, making them as digestible as a bowl of comforting dal bhat. Epistemology in the Upanishads is similar to the journey of a skilled potter. Just as a potter distinguishes between good and bad clay, the Upanishads delineate the difference between valid and invalid sources of knowledge. Direct experience, inference, and valid testimony in this context are like the potter's wheel, molding raw information into polished knowledge. The ethical teachings of the Upanishads echo throughout the busy markets of India. Just as every vendor in the market is expected to deal honestly with customers, the Upanishads urge us to adhere to principles like truth, nonviolence, and self-discipline, no matter what life throws at us. It's like the moral compass that guides a traveller through the bustling streets of an unknown city. In terms of theology, the Upanishads are comparable to a well tended Indian garden where a multitude of flowers bloom in harmony. They propose a view of God that embraces diverse aspects, formless and with form transcendent and imminent. Much like a gardener who sees the beauty of every flower, the Upanishads teach us to perceive the divine in all facets of existence. Picture the Upanishads as a mystical Himalayan trek. It's a journey within to the summit of one's inner being. The accounts of direct experience of ultimate reality by sages in the Upanishads serve as signposts on this trek, guiding the aspirant towards their profound self realisation nation. Just as Sherpas guide mountaineers to the peak.

### **Topic 3 - Major Upanishads and Their Teachings**

Let's start with the Isha Upanishad, often hailed as a brief poetic scripture that encapsulates the essence of all Upanishads. Imagine the complexity of an entire ecosystem fitting into a seed. That's the Isha Upanishad for you. It introduces us to the concept of isha Vasyam, meaning to perceive everything in the universe as pervaded by a divine entity. This philosophy encourages living life fully yet detached, somewhat like enjoying a Bollywood movie, knowing it's not our real life. The canoe of Banishad is like the Indian virgin of Einstein's famous question, I want to know God's thoughts. The rest are details. It begins with a compelling question, Kena, meaning by whom? By whom is our mind directed? Who makes us live and dream? It explores the idea of the ultimate reality beyond the sensory

world, much like going beyond the obvious storyline in a book to understand its deeper themes. Kathao Panishad is a gripping dialogue between a young boy, Nachiket, and the God of death, Yam. It's a philosophical version of an engaging thriller movie, with the protagonist seeking answers to the enigma of death. It presents profound insights into the nature of the self that is Atman and the ultimate reality of Brahman. Sort of like revealing the secret behind the magic trick, but the magic is life itself. The Mundak Upanishad is akin to a how to manual for attaining the ultimate knowledge, much like a YouTube tutorial, but for life's most profound mysteries. It distinguishes between lower knowledge, upper vidya, the knowledge of the material world, like studying for your degree, and higher knowledge paravidya, the understanding of the ultimate truth, similar to gaining wisdom about life itself. If you've ever wondered about the mystery of sleep and dreams, the Mandukya Upanishad is like your dream analysis guide. It examines the three states of consciousness, waking, dreaming and deep sleep, and a fourth state called Turiya. It is like exploring the different stages of watching a movie, from being engrossed in the plot to pondering over it after it ends. Finally, Chandogya Upanishad, one of the oldest Upanishads, has the charm of a classic, timeless tale. It introduces the philosophy of Tattvam Asi or you are that suggests our true self is not separate from the universal truth. It's like discovering that you, the viewer, are an integral part of the movie you're watching, blurring the lines between reality and the silver screen. Close.

#### **Topic 4 - Concept of Brahman in Upanishads**

So let us try to understand the secret ideas, the mystic ideas of Atman and Brahman, because without that we cannot understand the core of the traditional Indian philosophy and the Upanishads. The Upanishads describe both the ideas of Atman and Brahman. And they also believed that Atman and Brahman are one. There is a famous sentence from Mandukya, Upanishad, and it is, I am Atma, Brahma. It is also known as Mahavakya. So I am Atma. This Atma is nothing else but the Brahma. And this is the highlight of the Upanishadic philosophy and even the later philosophy. In the Upanishads, we see that there used to be discourses and there used to be Shashtra sabhas. There used to be a group of people, wise people, sitting together and discussing these mystic ideas with each other because they were not easy to understand. They were not ordinary. They were not belonging to the day to day life. So even they had to discuss a lot. They had to speculate. And there is a very famous example from the BRuhadaranYakopanishad. This was the Sabha called by King Janaka. And this king Janaka asked a very famous scholar named Yadnavalkya. He asked

Yadnavalkya how to comprehend that the Atma exists. How do you understand that the Atma is there? Because it is not seen with the eyes. And there Yadnavalkya answered that we believe that the sun or the Moon are eternal. But even when the sun, Moon or even deity Agni becomes extinguished, then also Atma remains as it is. And therefore Atma is the Brilliance. Atma is the only Self Luminous Substance in this world. And that is how you have to believe that Atma exists. Then we need to know what is Brahman when we talk about Brahman. The Sanskrit Dhatu in the term Brahman is Brahmha. Brahmha means to increase, to expand. And Therefore Brahman means expansion or something which has occupied everything. You know, friends, the word Brahman is a very interesting word. We have already known about the Rigveda. You find the word Brahman in the Rigveda also. But in the Rigveda, the word Brahman means knowledge, and that knowledge is reflected through the Vedic mantras. But you can see that the concept evolved slowly. And when we read this word in the Upanishads, it means something which is omnipresent, something which occupies everything. In one of the discussions in the Upanishads, you find that Brahman is something like salt. You must have done this experiment in childhood that mixes some salt in the water and then you don't see the existence of the salt, but you know that it is everywhere. In the same way, Brahma is everywhere. And therefore it is called Sarvam Kaluidam Brahma, which means all this, sarvam idam, all this is nothing else but the Brahma. And this brahman is something which is From which everything emanates, something with which everything is identified, and at the end, something to which everything returns. And through the Upanishads, we understand that Atman and Brahman are always interwoven. Although we are trying to look at two different identities, two different concepts in reality or as per the Upanishadic philosophy, they were never separate. They are never separate. They will be never separate. They are always together. So I am Atma Brahma. This atma is nothing else but the Brahma. When we think of the ocean, we see its vast expanse and unfathomable depth. Similarly, the Upanishads introduce us to the concept of Brahman, the ultimate reality or the absolute truth in the universe. Imagine Brahman as the cosmic ocean. From all forms of life and matter emerge, exist and eventually return. Describing the nature of Brahman can be as tricky as trying to paint the wind. The Upanishads explain Brahman as the SATA, Chitta, Ananda, existence, consciousness and bliss. Much like the Internet permeating every corner of our modern life, Brahman pervades everything, animate and inanimate. Yet it's beyond time, space and causation. The connection between the Brahman and

the universe can be compared to that of a web and a spider. Just as a spider spins and withdraws the web from itself, the universe emanates from, exists in, and eventually merges back into Brahman. However, Brahman itself remains unchanged, like gold remaining gold whether it's molded into a ring or a bangle. If Brahman is a hidden treasure, then the Upanishad suggests various paths to discover it, like using different modes of transportation to reach a destination. These paths include knowledge, which is nyan devotion, meaning bhakti actions, meaning karma, and meditation, which means dhyan, each suited to different individual dispositions. The Upanishads are rich with verses on Brahman, adding layers of understanding to this complex concept. To comprehend Brahman through these verses is akin to observing the reflection of the moon in various water bodies. Each reflection may be different, but the moon is the same. These verses provide nuanced perspectives on the nature and realization of Brahman. The Upanishadic concept of Brahman has greatly influenced later schools of Indian philosophy. Much like a tree seeding a forest advait. Vedanta, for instance, stands on the non-dualistic concept of Brahman, while Dwait Vedanta views Brahman, or God and the individual soul as distinct. The ripple effect of Brahman's philosophy can also be seen in various Indian art forms, literature, and cultural practices.

### **Topic 5 - Concept of Atman in Upanishads**

In the vast universe of Upanishadic philosophy, the Atman is like the source code of our existence. The term Atman refers to the innermost essence or the true self of an individual, often translated as soul or spirit. Imagine it as the unchanging core of your being, something that is untouched by the highs and lows of life, just like a serene lake that remains calm amidst a storm. Now, the nature of Atman is unique. It is believed to be eternal, unchanging and indivisible, quite unlike our ever changing personalities or physical bodies. Just as the constitution is the fundamental law that governs our country, the Atman is the fundamental eternal entity that exists beyond the transitory aspects of human life. The Upanishads discuss an intriguing relationship between the Atman and our individuality. While our identities might be like diverse dishes from the vast Indian culinary landscape, each one uni spicy, sweet or tangy, the atman is akin to the staple rice. Unwearing yet vital. It exists beyond our physical characteristics, personal history or social status, the constant core that remains unchanged. This is where it gets interesting. The Upanishads propose that the Atman, or the individual self and Brahman, the universal self, are ultimately one and the same, much like individual rivers and the vast ocean. This concept is

central to understanding the non dualistic perspective of Indian philosophy. Several verses in the Upanishads deeply explore the nature of the Atma. Much like how the national anthem brings out our patriotism, these verses evoke a sense of self realisation, reminding us of the eternal and unchanging nature of the Atman. The concept of Atman has significantly influenced later schools of Indian philosophy. Like different genres of music that have evolved from classical roots, many spiritual practices and philosophical debates in India revolve around the understanding and realization of the Atman, underlining its enduring significance.

### **Topic 6 - Concept of Maya In Upanishads**

while reading the philosophical texts, you come across one more term, and that is Maya. So what is Maya? This word is very old. You find this word in the Rigveda, the first Vedic text. But in the Rigveda, the meaning of this word was supernatural power or divine power. And as we saw that the word Brahman changed its meaning, in the same way, the word Maya also changed its meaning. Slowly this word was used in the sense of illusion, deception, and even magic. Sometimes you can see that in the Vedic language, it is also understood as witchcraft. But now what we are talking about is the Maya. From the philosophical perspective, we find the word Maya especially in the later philosophy. It has this very sense of illusion. And what kind of illusion is this? Here, Maya means something because of how we see the world. So the world is not the reality, the variety in the world. There are human beings, there are animals, there are non-living things, there are trees, this and that. This variety in the world is seen by us because there is Maya. Through Maya, we see this through illusion, we see this. This was what the philosophers believed. And they also said. They also stated that in reality there is only one existence. We saw the Brahman, only the true or ultimate principle and the world is nothing else but an illusion. Therefore, the Brahman or ultimate principle is the reality, and the world is unreality. But I must tell you that this concept of Maya is not directly seen in the Upanishads. The seeds of this Maya are visible in the Upanishads. Maya is a challenging yet central concept in Upanishadic philosophy. In simple terms, it is often understood as an illusion or unreality. It's like watching a film. What you see on the screen feels real, but it's just a projection, a play of light and sound. Similarly, Maya refers to our perception of the world as tangible and separate. When in Upanishadic thought, it is more akin to a cosmic illusion, obscuring the underlying unity of existence. Imagine you're walking in a dim light and mistake a rope for a snake. Your heart might race and you might even

scream. But the truth is, it was always a rope. Maya is similar. It is characterized by two powers, veiling meaning avaran and projection, which means vic shape, like the dim light veiling the rope's true nature and your mind, projecting it as a snake. Maya veils the ultimate reality, which means Brahman, and projects the world as we know it. If Brahman is the ocean, Maya is what makes us perceive the waves as separate entities. It creates a world of diversity from the underlying oneness of Brahman. It's like using different filters on a photo editing app. The picture remains the same, but the filters or Maya make it appear differently. To transcend Maya is to realize that the world as we perceive it is not the ultimate reality. It's like realizing the movie on the screen is not real life. The Upanishad suggests this can be achieved through knowledge or jnana, devotion, meaning bhakti and discipline, practice or yoga. Think of it as tearing the fog from a window to see the clear view outside. Several Upanishadic verses discuss Maya. For instance, the Shweta Shwatara Upanishad states, that know Maya as Prakriti on nature and the wielder of the Maya as the great Lord himself. These verses aim to provide insights into the nature of Maya and how to transcend it. It's like a treasure map guiding us beyond the illusion to the ultimate reality. The concept of Maya played a significant role in later philosophical schools, particularly in Advait Vedanta, where it was further elaborated by Adi Shankaracharya. Like the seeds of a tree that grow and branch out, the Upanishadek concept of Maya was the seed that grew into a philosophical tree in later times.

## **Topic 7 - Influence of Upanishads on Indian Thought and Culture**

You see, these ancient ideas and ancient texts have a deep rooted effect on even present Indian thought and culture. And Upanishads are not the exception. We saw that the Upanishads had some moral ideas and a very deep philosophy. One of them is known to us. Karma siddhanta. What is Karma Siddhanta? Karma means the action. And this Siddhanta or this theory of action tells us that if you perform good actions they will result in merit punya. And if you perform evil actions they will result in demerits or blemishes. That is paap. And we learn these ideas right from our childhood. But where do you find these? They are mentioned in the Upanishads. And this Karma Siddhanta is still existing in our society. And if we follow this idea, we all will become good citizens. I believe there is one story which also tells us about certain ideas such as charity, compassion and control over desires. In Sanskrit, they are called Dhana, charity, Daya, compassion and Dhamma Indriya, Dhamana. That is, control over the desires. So this story is of Prajapati and his three sons. So Prajapati is supposed

to be the father of all. And he had three sons. Who are they? The God, the demon and the man. So, Deva, Danava and Manava. These were the three children of Prajapati. Now, when they grew up, they thought that we must get something from our father. So it was like the property which was with their father. And they wanted a part of that property. So they went to Prajapati and they requested him to, please give us something from your riches. So Prajapati gave them these three things to the Manava, to the human being, he said the. To the Danava, he said the. And to the deva, the God, he said the. Now, the interpretation of these three das is Dhana, Daya and Dhamma. So, to the Manava, to the human beings, Prajapati said that you should always make charities. If you have ample money, you should give it to the needy people. Then comes the gods. You know, the gods are almighty. They can become arrogant. But Prajapati told them that, no, you should always have Daya. You should always have compassion towards your devotees. You should always have compassion for your devotees and everything else. And then comes Danava. The demon and the demons have power. But at the same time, they have a mentality. They might have a thought process to trouble others. As you know the stories of the demons. So Prajapati told the dhanavas that you should have dhamma, you should have control over your desires so that you will not use your power in a wrong way and you will not harass the common people. So this is how we can see that there are many takeaways from the Upanishads and after so many years we still have those values and those ideas existing in our society. The Upanishads have greatly influenced the various schools of Hindu philosophy. Just as the multitude of rivers in India merge into the sea, the philosophies of Dwait Advait and Vishishtha Dwait have found their roots in the Upanishads, borrowing profound concepts like Atman, Brahman and Maya. These philosophies are much like different paths that all lead to the summit of a mountain, diverse in their approach but converging in their ultimate truth. The Bhagti movement, a significant socio cultural revolution that emphasized personal devotion to deities, also echoed many Upanishadic teachings. Like a traditional Indian rag that improvises upon a bass melody, the Bhakti saints incorporated Upanishadek idols into their heartfelt songs of devotion, underscoring the fundamental unity of all beings and promoting social harmony. The Upanishads, like the foundational stones in a magnificent Indian temple, have shaped the architecture of Indian culture. The festivals, rituals and social norms we observe today are often rooted in the Upanishadic philosophy of dharma, promoting peace, harmony and a sense of interconnectedness among

individuals and with nature. Yoga, India's timeless gift to the world, mirrors Upanishadic principles of mind, body unity and conscious living. Like the synchronized rhythm of a classical Indian dance, yoga integrates the physical, mental and spiritual aspects of human life, embodying the holistic approach to well being propagated in the Upanishads. Today's modern spiritual movements, much like the vibrant hues of an Indian rangoli, draw upon the vibrant wisdom of the Upanishads. These age-old teachings resonate even today, encouraging introspection, mindfulness and a deeper understanding of oneself, self and the universe, thereby fostering a sense of inner peace amidst the rush of modern life. Close.

### **Topic 8 - Upanishads in the Modern World**

Think of the Upanishads as an age old wisdom tree and modern science like a budding plant in comparison. You may be surprised to know, but these two, despite their age difference, often share common insights. Take for instance the Upanishadic concept of Brahman, an all encompassing reality which resonates with modern theories in quantum physics that propose a connected, unified field underlying all existence. This ancient wisdom helps us appreciate the sophisticated perspectives our ancestors held about the universe, many of which are being revisited today in the light of modern scientific discovery. The Upanishads, though ancient, hold conversations that feel like they are a part of today's philosophical details. The questions they raise about the selves, consciousness, and reality, are being actively explored in modern philosophical and cognitive science discourse. In many ways, the Upanishads laid the groundwork for discussions about consciousness and identity that many philosophers are grappling with today. Let's think of the human mind as an unexplored jungle and psychologists as explorers, the Upanishads have acted as an ancient map, guiding these modern explorers to understand the quantities of human consciousness. They provide profound insights into human nature, emotions, desires and the paths to achieve peace of mind. The concept of mindfulness, for instance, echoed in the Upanishads, is a popular therapeutic practice in modern psychology. The Upanishads are much like the moral compass of a ship, guiding us through the turbulent seas of ethical dilemmas. They advocate for virtues like truthfulness, nonviolence, self discipline and compassion, all of which are core to today's discussions on ethics and moral philosophy. Their teachings on karma and the interconnectedness of all beings encourage ethical conduct and social responsibility. Imagine the earth as our home and us its caretakers. The Upanishads teach us that we are a part of the

environment and not apart from it. Concepts such as Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam, the world is one family, have profound implications on our understanding of environmental conservation, encouraging us to care for nature as we would for our own family. This resonates deeply with modern environmental movements and their focus on ecological responsibility. Life today, much like a speeding metro, is fast paced and often stressful. Here, the Upanishads act as calming station stops, encouraging us to slow down and introspect. They guide us towards a balanced lifestyle and ment till peace. Ideas from the Upanishads, such as living mindfully and pursuing inner contentment, are being incorporated into wellness programs and self help literature worldwide, influencing contemporary lifestyles and well being. Close.

### **Topic 9 - Critiques and Interpretations of the Upanishads**

Over the centuries, scholars have written extensive commentaries on the Upanishads, interpreting them through various philosophical senses. The early commentators, such as Adi Shankaracharya, provided an advait Vedant interpretation, emphasizing on nonduality. It's like wearing different glasses to look at a vibrant painting. Each pair of glasses would highlight different colours and shades. Similarly, each interpretation brings out unique aspects of the Upanishads. Modern critics have focused on aspects like the historical context, social structures, and gender roles implicit in the Upanishads, just as a modern literary analyst may dissect a classic novel by examining the cultural and historical context in which it was written. Similarly, modern critics analyze the Upanishads within their socio historical context. They seek to understand these ancient texts in light of contemporary philosophical and social perspectives. Western philosophers like Schopenhauer and Thoreau were deeply influenced by the Upanishads, finding parallels with Western metaphysical thought. To visualize this, consider the confluence of two rivers, each bringing its unique elements but mixing to create a rich and diverse ecosystem. The Upanishads, interpreted through a Western lens, have created a rich blend of east-west philosophical dialogue. The Upanishads have been compared with other philosophical systems such as Buddhism, Sufism, and even Greek philosophy. Think of it as comparing the recipes of different cuisines. Each has its distinct flavours, but the underlying elements, like the use of spices or cooking techniques, might have striking similarities. These comparative studies bring out the universal aspects of human thought as reflected in the Upanishads. The varied interpretations of the Upanishads have greatly influenced Indian thought, shaping philosophical debates and spiritual practices. It's akin to how the

continuous reshaping of clay by a potter leads to various forms of pottery. Similarly, the diverse interpretations have molded Indian philosophy, leading to a rich and multifaceted spiritual heritage. The Upanishads continue to remain relevant today, offering timeless wisdom about the nature of reality, the self, and the cosmos. They inspire us to question, reflect, and seek answers. It's like a compass in the complex journey of life, offering direction to those who seek it. The modern world, with its rapid changes and challenges, can find in the Upanishads a source of deep insight and inner peace.

### **Topic 10 - Summary and Conclusion**

ladies and gentlemen, think of the Upanishads as a gigantic philosophical jigsaw puzzle. Each piece, whether it's Brahman, Atman, Maya, or the philosophical underpinnings, has its place in the grand tapestry of Indian philosophical thought. Each piece has provided us with a unique perspective on the nature of reality, knowledge, and the self, much like how every different puzzle piece helps form the overall picture. Picture India as a grand old banyan tree. If so, the Upanishads are like the deep entwined roots that hold this tree firm. They have profoundly influenced not just the diverse school of Hindu philosophy but also shaped social norms, spiritual practices, and intellectual discourses, much like how roots provide nourishment to every part of the tree. Upanishad teachings aren't like dusty old textbooks locked in a forgotten library they are more like timeless guidebooks. They offer wisdom for everyday living. Think of them as a kind of Google map for navigating the complexities of life. Concepts like dharma or duty karma, which means action and consequence and moksha, which means liberation, can guide us to lead meaningful and balanced lives.

### **Learning outcomes:**

- 1] Explain the origins and historical significance of the Upanishads.
- 2] Identify and describe the philosophical underpinnings of the Upanishads.
- 3] Analyse the teachings and key concepts of major Upanishads.
- 4] Understand the concepts of Brahman, Atman, and Maya in the Upanishads.
- 5] Recognise the influence of Upanishads on Indian thought and culture.
- 6] Evaluate the modern relevance and interpretations of the Upanishads.